



HubSpot CRM

PROFESSIONAL DATA OPTIMIZATION GUIDE

Eliminate Duplicate Contacts & Companies in HubSpot

A step-by-step playbook to identify, merge, and prevent duplicate records — restoring data integrity and maximizing your CRM investment.



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 SECTION 01

Why Duplicate Records Are Harmful

Duplicate records are one of the most damaging data quality issues in any CRM. Left unchecked, they erode trust in your data, waste team time, and directly hurt revenue.



Email Fatigue

Contacts receive the same campaign multiple times, leading to unsubscribes and spam complaints.



Inaccurate Reporting

Sales forecasts, pipeline metrics, and ROI calculations are inflated and unreliable.



Wasted Budget

You pay for duplicate contacts in your HubSpot plan tier and marketing send limits.



Poor Sales Experience

Reps unknowingly contact the same prospect twice, damaging professional relationships.



Broken Automation

Workflows, sequences, and lead scoring fire incorrectly on duplicate records.



Compliance Risk

GDPR / CAN-SPAM compliance becomes difficult when the same person has multiple records.



Industry Benchmark

Research shows that **10–30% of CRM records are duplicates** in a typical database. For a HubSpot portal with 10,000 contacts, that could mean up to 3,000 duplicate records silently degrading your operations.

Identify Duplicate **Contacts**

HubSpot provides a native deduplication tool for contacts on Professional and Enterprise tiers. Here is how to use it alongside manual methods.

1

Use HubSpot's Native Duplicate Management Tool

HubSpot automatically identifies potential duplicate contacts based on email address, name similarity, and other properties.

- ▶ Go to **Contacts** → **Contacts** in the top navigation.
- ▶ Click **Actions** → **Manage Duplicates** (top-right area).
- ▶ HubSpot will display a list of suspected duplicate pairs side-by-side.
- ▶ Review each pair and choose to **Merge** or **Not a Duplicate**.

2

Export & Analyze in Excel / Google Sheets

For large databases, exporting and filtering by key fields gives you full visibility.

- ▶ Go to **Contacts** → click **Export** (top right).
- ▶ Export properties: **Email, First Name, Last Name, Phone, Company Name, Create Date** .
- ▶ In Excel: Sort by **Email** , then use **COUNTIF** to flag duplicates.
- ▶ Use **Conditional Formatting** → **Highlight Duplicate Values** for visual review.
- ▶ Use **=LOWER(TRIM(A2))** to normalize emails before comparison.

```
// Excel formula to flag duplicates
Column A: Email addresses (all lowercase/trimmed)
Column B: =COUNTIF($A:$A, A2) → values > 1 are duplicates
Filter: Filter Column B for values >= 2
```

3

Create a Filtered View for Duplicates

Build a saved contact view in HubSpot to surface records with missing or suspicious data that often indicate duplicates.

- ▶ Go to **Contacts** → **Add Filter** .
- ▶ Filter: **Email** is unknown → finds contacts without email (common in duplicates).
- ▶ Filter: **Create Date** is recent → catches newly imported duplicates.
- ▶ Filter: **Number of associated deals** is 0 → orphan contacts often from imports.
- ▶ Save the view as **"Possible Duplicates Review"** .

4

Check Duplication by Phone Number

Email-based deduplication misses contacts with different email formats but the same phone number.

- ▶ Export contacts with **Phone Number** field included.
- ▶ Sort and apply **COUNTIF** on the Phone column.
- ▶ Cross-reference matched phone numbers with names to confirm duplicates.



HubSpot Plan Requirement

The native **Manage Duplicates** tool is available on **HubSpot Professional and Enterprise** plans for both Contacts and Companies. Starter plan users will need to rely on manual export/filter methods or third-party apps.

Identify Duplicate Companies

Company duplicates are often trickier — the same business may be entered as "Acme Inc.", "Acme Inc", "ACME", and "Acme International". Here's how to find them all.

1

Use HubSpot's Company Duplicate Manager

HubSpot matches companies primarily by **company domain name**.

- ▶ Go to **Companies** → **Actions** → **Manage Duplicates** .
- ▶ HubSpot shows pairs matched by domain, name similarity, and phone.
- ▶ Review each pair and confirm which record to keep as the **primary** .

2

Export & Clean by Domain Name

Domain is the most reliable unique identifier for companies. Use it as your primary deduplication key.

- ▶ Export companies with: **Company Name, Domain, Phone, City, Create Date, Number of Contacts** .
- ▶ Sort by **Domain Name** column.
- ▶ Use **COUNTIF** on Domain to flag duplicates.
- ▶ For companies without a domain: group by **Company Name** after normalizing case.

```
// Normalize company names for comparison
=LOWER(TRIM(SUBSTITUTE(A2,"Inc.", "")))
// Strip common suffixes: Inc, LLC, Ltd, Corp
=TRIM(SUBSTITUTE(SUBSTITUTE(SUBSTITUTE(A2,"Inc", ""),"LLC", ""),"Ltd", ""))
```

3

Identify Companies With Too Many Contacts

When duplicate companies exist, contacts get split between them. Finding companies with disproportionately few contacts can reveal fragments.

- ▶ In the export, sort by **Number of Associated Contacts** ascending.
- ▶ Companies with 0–1 contacts but a matching domain/name are likely duplicates.
- ▶ Compare against the primary company record by domain.



Pro Tip: Domain as the Golden Key

Always ensure the **Company Domain Name** property is populated for every company record. HubSpot uses this field to automatically associate contacts and prevent future duplicates. Make this a required field in your import templates.

How to Merge Duplicate **Contacts**

Merging combines two contact records into one, preserving all associated data including deals, emails, notes, and activities from both records.



Important: Merges Are Permanent

HubSpot merges **cannot be undone**. Always export a backup of your contacts before starting a bulk merge process. Go to **Contacts** → **Export** and save the full export file.

A

Method A: Merge via Manage Duplicates Tool (Recommended)

The fastest and safest built-in approach.

- ▶ Navigate to **Contacts** → **Actions** → **Manage Duplicates** .
- ▶ Review the duplicate pair displayed side-by-side.
- ▶ Select which record will be **Primary** (the one to keep — its record ID is preserved).
- ▶ The primary contact retains its properties unless the secondary has more recent data.
- ▶ Click **Merge** to combine. All timeline activity is merged into the primary record.
- ▶ Repeat for each pair in the queue.

B

Method B: Merge from the Contact Record

Use this when you know the two specific records to merge.

- ▶ Open the **primary contact record** you want to keep.
- ▶ Click the **Actions** button (top right of the record).
- ▶ Select **Merge** .
- ▶ Search for and select the **duplicate contact** to merge into the primary.
- ▶ Review the property conflict resolution panel.
- ▶ Confirm and click **Merge** .

C

Method C: Bulk Merge via HubSpot API

For advanced users with large-scale duplicates — use the HubSpot Contacts API to merge records programmatically.

```
// HubSpot API - Merge Contacts (POST)
URL: https://api.hubapi.com/contacts/v1/contact/merge-vids/<primaryId>/

Method: POST
Headers:
  Authorization: Bearer YOUR_ACCESS_TOKEN
  Content-Type: application/json

Body:
{
  "vidToMerge": <duplicateContactId>
}
```

- ▶ Use your exported duplicate list to generate merge pairs.
- ▶ Script the API calls using Python, Node.js, or Postman.
- ▶ Process in batches of 50–100 records and add a delay to avoid rate limits.



What Happens When You Merge?

- All **timeline activities** (emails, calls, notes, meetings) from both records are combined.
- **Associated deals, tickets, and companies** are retained on the primary record.
- **Property values:** The primary record's values are kept by default; you can override selected fields during merge.
- The secondary record's **Contact ID (VID)** is permanently removed.
- Any **list memberships** from both records are preserved on the primary.

How to Merge Duplicate Companies

Merging company records consolidates all associated contacts, deals, and activities under one authoritative company profile.

1

Merge via Manage Duplicates (Companies)

- ▶ Go to **Companies** → **Actions** → **Manage Duplicates** .
- ▶ Review each duplicate pair. Note **number of associated contacts and deals** on each.
- ▶ Select the record with more complete data and more associations as the **Primary** .
- ▶ Click **Merge** . All contacts, deals, and properties from the secondary are moved to the primary.

2

Merge from a Company Record

- ▶ Open the **primary company record** .
- ▶ Click **Actions** → **Merge** .
- ▶ Search for the duplicate company name.
- ▶ Confirm which record to keep and click **Merge** .

3

Reassign Orphan Contacts Before Merging

Before merging companies, ensure contacts associated with the secondary company are correctly linked.

- ▶ On the secondary company record, open the **Contacts** panel.
- ▶ Verify each contact should belong to the primary company.
- ▶ If needed, manually update the contact's **Company** association before merging.
- ▶ Proceed with the merge once associations are verified.

Property	Behavior During Company Merge	Action Required
Company Name	Primary record's name is retained	Choose primary as the correctly named record
Domain Name	Primary domain is retained; secondary stored as alias	Verify the primary has the correct domain
Associated Contacts	All contacts from both records are moved to primary	Review for any mismatched contacts after merge
Associated Deals	All deals from secondary are moved to primary	Review deal names/stages for accuracy
Timeline Activity	Combined from both records	No action needed
Custom Properties	Primary values win; secondary values discarded	Copy important secondary values before merging

Recommended Third-Party Tools

For databases with thousands of duplicates, native HubSpot tools can be time-consuming. These specialized tools provide automation, fuzzy matching, and bulk processing.



Dedupely

HubSpot Native Integration

The most popular HubSpot deduplication app. Uses fuzzy matching to find duplicates that HubSpot's native tool misses. Supports bulk auto-merge with rules.

Fuzzy Name Match

Bulk Merge

Auto Rules



Insycle

Data Management Platform

A comprehensive CRM data management tool for HubSpot. Handles deduplication, data standardization, bulk editing, and import templates.

Deduplication

Data Cleansing

Bulk Edit



Databox / Supermetrics

Data Audit & Reporting

Use for ongoing data quality monitoring and identifying data anomalies in your HubSpot portal. Good for building duplicate-detection dashboards.

Monitoring

Reporting



Clearbit Enrichment

Data Enrichment

Enrich contact and company records with verified data from Clearbit. Helps normalize and complete records before deduplication, reducing false positives.

Enrichment

Normalization



Python + HubSpot API

Custom Script

For technical teams: write a custom deduplication script using Python and the HubSpot API. Full control over matching logic, merge rules, and logging.

- Full Control
- Custom Logic
- Auditable



HubSpot Import Tool

Built-in (Free)

Use HubSpot's import tool with the "Update existing records" option to standardize properties across duplicates before merging them manually.

- Free
- Built-in
- Update Records

Tool	Best For	Pricing	Fuzzy Match	Bulk Merge
HubSpot Native	Small databases (<5k records)	Free / Pro+	Limited	Manual
Dedupely	Mid-size databases	From \$25/mo	✔ Yes	✔ Yes
Insycle	Full data governance	From \$49/mo	✔ Yes	✔ Yes
Python API Script	Large / complex databases	Free (dev cost)	Custom	✔ Yes

Duplicate Prevention Strategy

Cleaning duplicates is a one-time fix. Prevention is the ongoing discipline that keeps your CRM healthy. These practices eliminate duplicates at the source.

FORM SETTINGS

Enable "Update existing contact" on all HubSpot Forms

In your HubSpot form settings, enable "**Update contact if contact already exists**". This ensures that when a known contact submits a form, HubSpot updates their record instead of creating a new one. This is the single most impactful setting for preventing form-based duplicates.

IMPORT RULES

Always use "Update existing records" during CSV imports

When importing contact lists, always select the option to **update existing records** rather than creating new ones. Use **Email Address** as the unique identifier for contacts and **Domain Name** for companies during every import.

WORKFLOWS

Build a Duplicate Detection Workflow

Create a HubSpot workflow that triggers on **Contact Created**. The workflow checks if the email domain already exists and sends an internal notification to a CRM admin for review. This provides a real-time alert system for new potential duplicates.

TEAM TRAINING

Train all CRM users on duplicate prevention

Before manually creating a contact or company, team members should always **search HubSpot first**. Establish a policy: *"Search before you create."* Include this in your CRM onboarding SOP for all new sales and marketing team members.

API INTEGRATION

Validate records before sending to HubSpot from third-party apps

If you're sending data to HubSpot from other systems (Salesforce, Shopify, etc.), build a **pre-insert check** using the HubSpot Search API to verify whether a contact or company already exists before creating a new

record.



SCHEDULED AUDIT

Schedule a monthly deduplication audit

Deduplicate your CRM is not a one-time task. Set a recurring calendar event every **30 days** for a CRM admin to run the Manage Duplicates tool and review the results. Use a Dedupely or Insyncle scheduled scan if available in your plan.



HubSpot's Automatic Deduplication (Always Active)

HubSpot automatically deduplicates contacts by **email address** — you cannot have two contacts with the exact same email. For companies, HubSpot deduplicates by **company domain name**. Ensuring every record has these fields populated activates HubSpot's built-in protection.

Ongoing Maintenance Checklist

Use this checklist as a recurring data hygiene process to maintain a clean, accurate HubSpot CRM.



Monthly Tasks

- ✓ Run Manage Duplicates for Contacts
- ✓ Run Manage Duplicates for Companies
- ✓ Review contacts with no email address
- ✓ Review companies with no domain name
- ✓ Archive contacts with no activity in 12+ months
- ✓ Check for contacts with duplicate phone numbers



Quarterly Tasks

- ✓ Full export and Excel duplicate analysis
- ✓ Review and update CRM import SOP
- ✓ Audit HubSpot form settings for all forms
- ✓ Verify all API integrations use update-or-create logic
- ✓ Train any new team members on CRM data policy
- ✓ Review and optimize contact lifecycle stages



Assign a CRM Data Owner

Data quality degrades without ownership. Designate one person (or a small team) as the **CRM Data Owner** responsible for running these audits, enforcing data entry standards, and approving all bulk imports. Without a named owner, deduplication work will slip.

Action	Frequency	Tool	Owner
Run Contact Duplicate Manager	Monthly	HubSpot Native	CRM Admin
Run Company Duplicate Manager	Monthly	HubSpot Native	CRM Admin
Export + Excel Duplicate Audit	Quarterly	HubSpot + Excel	CRM Admin
Dedupely / Insycle Scheduled Scan	Weekly (automated)	Dedupely / Insycle	Automated
Verify form "update existing" setting	Quarterly	HubSpot Forms	Marketing Ops
Team CRM training / refresher	Quarterly	Internal SOP	CRM Owner

HubSpot CRM Optimization Guide

This document provides a comprehensive, professional framework for eliminating duplicate contacts and companies in HubSpot CRM, and maintaining data quality on an ongoing basis.

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